

Video Jihad and Pakistan



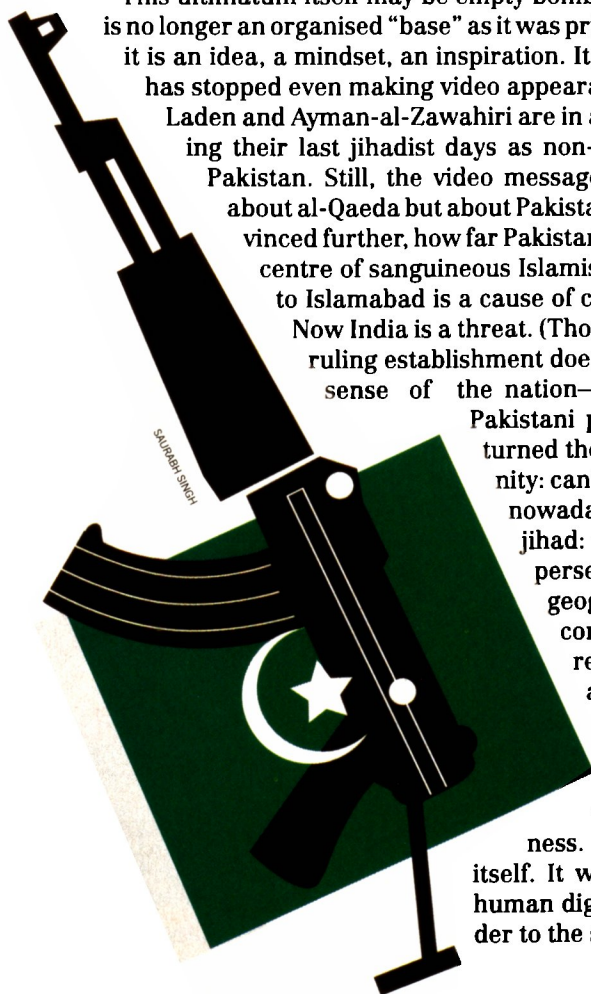
Guess who's coming to the rescue of Pakistan, the poor little Islamic state threatened by godless enemies from far and near. From Washington, now the global capital of change, the new leader of the free world has shifted his gaze from Mesopotamia. Iraq was the costliest screw up, surge or no surge; so the man with the mandate to restore happiness in the superpower on Prozac has set his disapproving eyes on the other battlefield (lately neglected by his Baghdad-obsessed predecessor). Afghanistan is where the war on terror should be, President Barack Obama has decreed. And can you say Afghanistan, where Taliban are on a comeback, without Pakistan? Project Taliban was—and is—a Pakistani nationalist mission. Post-Mumbai, the status of our Islamic neighbour as the rogue state of the East has grown manifold. India has living proof. Pakistan needs protection; and it has come from those who are indebted to the rogue. In the latest instance of video jihad, al-Qaeda has declared war on India: "If you make that mistake (of attacking Muslims in Pakistan), then you should know, with the command of Allah, you will have to pay a heavy price and ultimately you will be destined to humiliation. The Mujahideen will sunder your armies into the ground, like they did to the Russians in Afghanistan. They will target your economic centres and raze them to the ground."

This ultimatum itself may be empty bombast, for al-Qaeda is no longer an organised "base" as it was prior to 9/11. Today, it is an idea, a mindset, an inspiration. Its troglodyte chief has stopped even making video appearances. Osama bin Laden and Ayman-al-Zawahiri are in all probability living their last jihadist days as non-paying guests of Pakistan. Still, the video message says a lot—not

about al-Qaeda but about Pakistan. It shows, as if we need to be convinced further, how far Pakistan has gone to become the throbbing centre of sanguineous Islamism. Any danger, perceived or real, to Islamabad is a cause of concern for the jihadist movement.

Now India is a threat. (Though it is a different matter that our ruling establishment doesn't have the political will—or that sense of the nation—to face up to the evil.) And the

Pakistani propaganda machine has already turned the threat into a nationalist opportunity: can't you see Islamabad playing victim nowadays? This is the supreme conceit of jihad: the killer driven by the fantasy of persecution. Pakistan today is the geographical manifestation of that conceit. We should not be alone in repudiating it, and we should not be alone in suffering its consequences either. That is why whenever Obama asks Islamabad to come clean on al-Qaeda and Taliban, we doubt whether he means business. He is asking Pakistan to disown itself. It won't. Partners in democracy and human dignity should be one in their rejoinder to the state that threatens us all.



**THIS IS THE
SUPREME
CONCEIT OF
JIHAD: THE
KILLER DRIVEN
BY THE
FANTASY OF
PERSECUTION.**

SIGNPOSTS

ARRESTED: Deputy SP **K.G. Erda** by the Special Investigation Team for alleged destruction of evidence, abetment and other crimes during the 2002 Gujarat riots. He is the first police officer to be arrested in the case.

WON: By tabla maestro **Ustad Zakir Hussain** for his album *Global Drum Project*, the Grammy



for Contemporary World Music Album in Los Angeles. This is his second Grammy.

WON: By **Prakash Amritraj** and American **Rajeev Ram**, the doubles final at the ATP Challenger in Dallas, Texas.

PRESENTED: To Hindustani vocalist **Pandit Bhimsen Joshi**, 87, the Bharat Ratna, India's highest civilian award. Normally given away at the Ashoka Hall in the Rashtrapati Bhavan, the award was presented at Joshi's Pune residence in view of his ill health.

